Low mood, sadness and depression

Most people feel low sometimes, but if it's affecting your life, there are things you can try that may help.

Support is also available if you're finding it hard to cope with low mood, sadness or depression.

Symptoms of a low mood

Symptoms of a general low mood may include feeling:

sad
anxious or panicky
more tired than usual or being unable to sleep
angry or frustrated
low on confidence or self-esteem

A low mood often gets better after a few days or weeks.

It's usually possible to improve a low mood by making small changes in your life. For example, resolving something that's bothering you or getting more sleep.

Symptoms of depression

If you have a low mood that lasts 2 weeks or more, it could be a sign of depression.

Other symptoms of depression may include:

not getting any enjoyment out of life
feeling hopeless
not being able to concentrate on everyday things
having suicidal thoughts or thoughts about harming yourself

Things you can try to help with a low mood

Do

try talking about your feelings to a friend, family member, health professional or counsellor. You could also contact Samaritans by calling 116 123 if you need someone to talk to

try the 6 ways to feel happier, which are simple lifestyle changes to help you feel more in control and able to cope

find out how to raise your self-esteem

consider peer support, where people use their experiences to help each other. Find out more about peer support on the Mind website

try mindfulness, where you focus on the present moment

listen to free mental wellbeing audio guides

Don’t
do not try to do everything at once; set small targets that you can easily achieve

do not focus on the things you cannot change – focus your time and energy into helping yourself feel better

try not to tell yourself that you're alone – most people feel low sometimes and support is available

try not to use alcohol, cigarettes, gambling or drugs to relieve a low mood. These can all contribute to poor mental health

Health for Teens: advice about low mood
Every Mind Matters: mental wellbeing tips, including mindfulness, self-help cognitive behavioural therapy (CBT) techniques and free personalised advice to your email inbox
Where to get NHS help for a low mood
Referring yourself for therapy
If you need more support, you can get free talking therapies like cognitive behavioural therapy (CBT) on the NHS.

You can refer yourself directly to an NHS talking therapies service without a referral from a GP.

Find NHS talking therapies for anxiety and depression
If you're under 18, or want to get help for someone under 18, find out how to get mental health support for children and young people.

See a GP if:
you've had a low mood for more than 2 weeks
you're struggling to cope with a low mood
things you're trying yourself are not helping
you would prefer to get a referral from a GP
Ask for an urgent GP appointment or call 111 if:
you need help urgently, but it's not an emergency
111 can tell you the right place to get help if you need to see someone. Go to NHS 111 online or call 111.

Call 999 or go to A&E now if:
you or someone you know needs immediate help
you have seriously harmed yourself – for example, by taking a drug overdose
A mental health emergency should be taken as seriously as a medical emergency.

Find your nearest A&E

Do not drive to A&E. Ask someone to drive you or call 999 and ask for an ambulance.

Bring any medicines you take with you.

Causes of a low mood
There are many reasons why you might feel low at some point in your life.

Any sort of difficult event or experience could lead to sadness or low self-esteem. Sometimes it's possible to feel low without there being an obvious reason.

Identifying the cause
If you know what's causing your low mood it might be easier to find ways to manage it.

Some examples of things that may cause a low mood include:

work – feeling pressure at work, unemployment or retirement
family – relationship difficulties, divorce or caring for someone
financial problems – unexpected bills or borrowing money
health – illness, injury or losing someone (bereavement)
Even significant life events such as buying a house, having a baby or planning a wedding could lead to feelings of sadness.

You might find it hard to explain to people why you feel this way, but talking to someone could help you find a solution.

Find out more about the 5 steps to mental wellbeing

Conditions related to low mood and depression
Symptoms Possible cause
feeling low or depressed in a seasonal pattern, usually during winter seasonal affective disorder (SAD)
feeling low or depressed after the birth of a child postnatal depression